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Allianz Pulse 2026 on AI

The Uneasy AI Revolution: Rapid Adoption, Growing Anxiety and Europe's Preparedness Gap

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Executive Summary



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- **The Allianz Pulse Survey takes the temperature of European households each year on the economic, political and societal issues shaping their lives, with the 2026 edition focusing on artificial intelligence.** As AI moves into everyday life and work, the survey explores how people use the technology, what they expect from it and how prepared they feel for the changes it will bring. For its eighth edition, we surveyed a representative sample of 1,000 adults in each of Germany, France, Italy, Spain, Poland and Austria, adding the UK and US for the first time. This provides a transatlantic perspective on how people are experiencing and anticipating the AI transition.

- **Europe is embracing AI, but adoption is less advanced and less work related than in the US, with large differences within Europe.** Across all eight countries surveyed, 48% of respondents use AI at least weekly, with the US and Spain leading at around 55%, while Germany, France and Austria remain in the low 40s. The generational divide is particularly striking: 77% of Gen Z use AI weekly, compared with just 23% of Boomers. Moreover, adoption has yet to translate fully into workplace use: among AI users, 53% use it mainly for private purposes, 20% mainly for work or study and 27% across both contexts. Just under half therefore use AI at least partly for work or study, with the share highest in the US (52%), the UK (51%) and Spain (49%), but only 37% in Germany. Germany stands out as the country where AI adoption is most concentrated in private life, while Spain shows that high AI adoption and workplace use are not uniquely American.

- **Europeans see the benefits of AI for themselves, but are considerably more skeptical about what it means for the economy and jobs, especially compared with Americans.** Net sentiment towards AI is -34% overall, meaning negative views exceed positive views by 34pp. It deteriorates to -43% for the economic impact and -67% for jobs. The views about the job impact of AI are deeply negative, even as positive productivity expectations exceed negative expectations by 30% across all respondents, while 35% expect little or no impact. The US provides a clear contrast on employment: its jobs sentiment stands at -44%, still negative but considerably less so than the survey average. Within Europe, the picture varies strongly: Austria (-81%) and France (-75%) are the most pessimistic about the AI impact on jobs, while Spain combines high AI adoption with less negative attitudes towards AI's expected job impact (-66%). Across countries, young, urban and high-income respondents are the demographic groups most positive about AI. More broadly, the observed AI skepticism is closely associated with an overall weak confidence in economic progress: respondents with negative views of AI also tend to hold gloomier views of both the economy and the future.

- **As AI adoption spreads, concerns about its impact on jobs are intensifying, even though most people expect task transformation rather than outright job destruction.** Among countries surveyed in both years, net sentiment on AI's impact on jobs fell by around 12pp, from -55% in 2025 to -67% in 2026. The deterioration was particularly pronounced in Europe: Austria's jobs balance fell by around 19pps, while Germany and France also recorded double digit declines. Yet this is not primarily a story of expected mass unemployment. Only 7% expect their job to disappear entirely, while 21% expect significant parts to be replaced and 26% expect AI mainly to augment their work. First-hand experience changes expectations substantially: 41% of workplace AI users anticipate augmentation, compared with only 11% of non-users, although they are also more likely to expect task replacement (40% versus 17%). Exposure appears to make both the risks and opportunities more tangible, particularly the potential for AI to support rather than replace workers.

- **Europe risks entering the AI transition with too little investment in workers, while training continues to favor those already ahead.** Only 17% of all employed respondents across countries have received AI training at work, compared with 30% in the US. The lack of training opportunities is a major bottleneck: 44% report that their employer offers no AI training at all. The European range is wide, with participation falling to just 10% in Poland, while training is also significantly more common among tertiary educated workers. This suggests that access to training risks reinforcing existing divides in skills and opportunity. The transatlantic contrast is particularly concerning: The US combines more intensive AI use with greater employer-led preparation, while parts of Europe combine limited workplace adoption with stronger fears of labor-market disruption.

- **People fear that AI will widen inequality and want stronger safeguards against its risks.** Across the entire sample, 37% expect AI to increase inequality, 34% think it will stay the same, compared with only 9% who expect a reduction. Austria records the strongest expectation of widening inequality, while Poland is the least concerned, though the balance is positive everywhere. People worry less about what AI might become than about harms it already causes: misinformation (25%), data privacy (21%) and job losses (17%) top the list, ahead of loss of control over advanced AI (16%). The net support for stronger regulation, calculated as the share of respondents in favor minus the share opposed, increased by 17pp, from +61% in 2025 to +78% in 2026. This does not signal outright resistance to AI: Spain combines high adoption with strong support for regulation, showing that enthusiasm for the technology and demand for safeguards can coexist.

- **For Europe, the central challenge is therefore to accelerate productive AI adoption while ensuring that its benefits are broadly shared.** The survey points to five priorities. First, move AI from private experimentation into productive workplace use by lowering implementation costs, especially for SMEs. Second, close the training gap through employer-led, occupation-specific learning. Third, shift labor-market policy from protecting existing jobs to supporting transitions into new tasks and roles. Fourth, make sure the productivity dividend is broadly shared through skills, wider household participation in capital markets and tax systems that adapt to shifts in income from labor to capital. Fifth, strengthen trust through targeted, proportionate regulation addressing misinformation, data misuse and labor-market risks without stifling innovation. Ultimately, success will be measured by AI's ability to deliver broadly shared productivity gains, stronger employability and greater confidence in economic progress.



Adoption: Broad but shallow and still mostly private

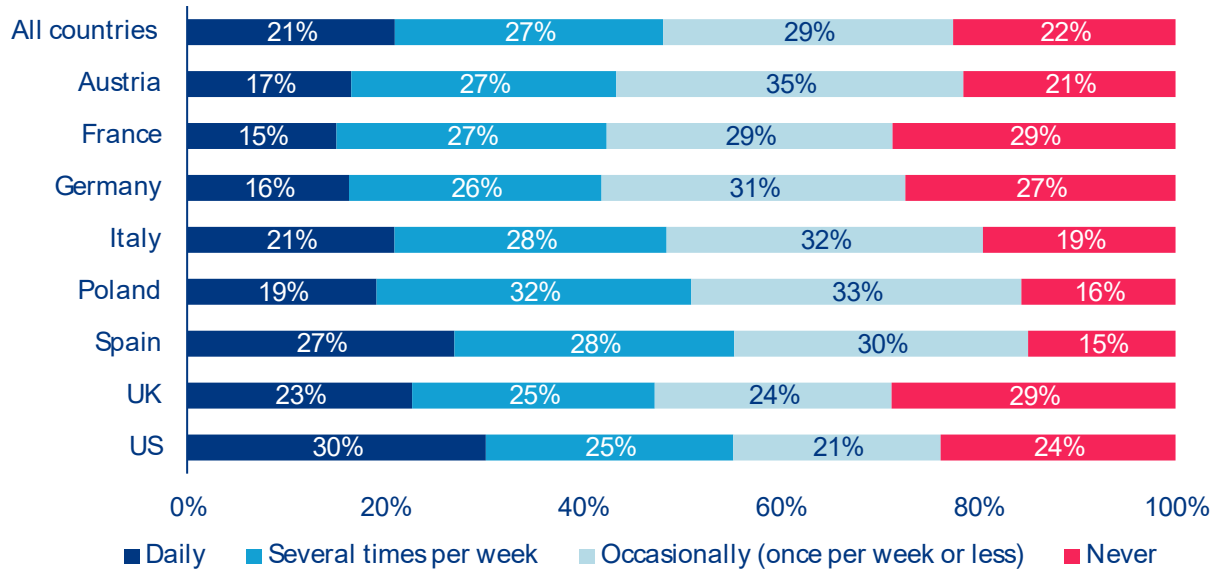
AI adoption is unfolding at historically unprecedented speed, but usage intensity remains uneven. Generative AI has reached mass adoption faster than earlier general-purpose technologies such as the personal computer or the internet, and our survey shows that more than three-quarters of respondents have already used AI tools. Yet only 21% use them daily and 22% have never used them at all (Figure 1). Weekly use reaches 48% across the sample, led by the US and Spain, at around 55%, while France, Germany and Austria remain in the low 40s. The transatlantic difference lies mainly in intensity rather than reach: the share that has never used AI is similar in Europe and the US, but daily use is materially higher in the US, at 30% compared with around 20% in Europe. Spain shows that high engagement is not uniquely American.

The largest divides are within societies rather than across the Atlantic. More than three-quarters, or 77%, of Gen Z use AI at least weekly, more than three times the 23% share among Boomers (Figure 2). Millennials are closest to Gen Z in AI adoption (65% weekly users), while Gen X (43%) occupy the middle ground. Large gaps also run through income, education and geography: 59% of high-income respondents use AI weekly compared with 40% of low-income respondents, while usage rises from 40% among the primary-educated to 58% among those with tertiary education. Urban respondents are also substantially more engaged than rural ones, at 57% versus 34%. The gender gap in weekly AI use is evident but smaller than other gaps: Weekly adoption is higher among men than women, at 51% versus 45%. Overall, AI use is already widespread, but the intensity and economic relevance of that use differs sharply across demographic groups.

AI is still used more in private life than at work. Among users, 53% employ AI primarily for private purposes, compared with 20% who use it mainly for work or study and 27% who use it for both (Figure 3). The private-use share ranges from 48% in the US to 63% in Germany, while exclusive work or study use varies only from 14% in Germany to 23% in France. Combining those who use AI mainly for work or study with those who use it across both professional and private contexts, just under half of users employ AI at least partly for work or study. The share is highest in the US (52%), the UK (51%) and Spain (49%), compared with only 37% in Germany. Germany therefore stands out as the clearest case where AI adoption remains concentrated in private life. The US and UK, by contrast, have the highest shares of users spanning both professional and private contexts, at 33% and 31%, respectively, suggesting somewhat deeper integration of AI across different parts of everyday life.

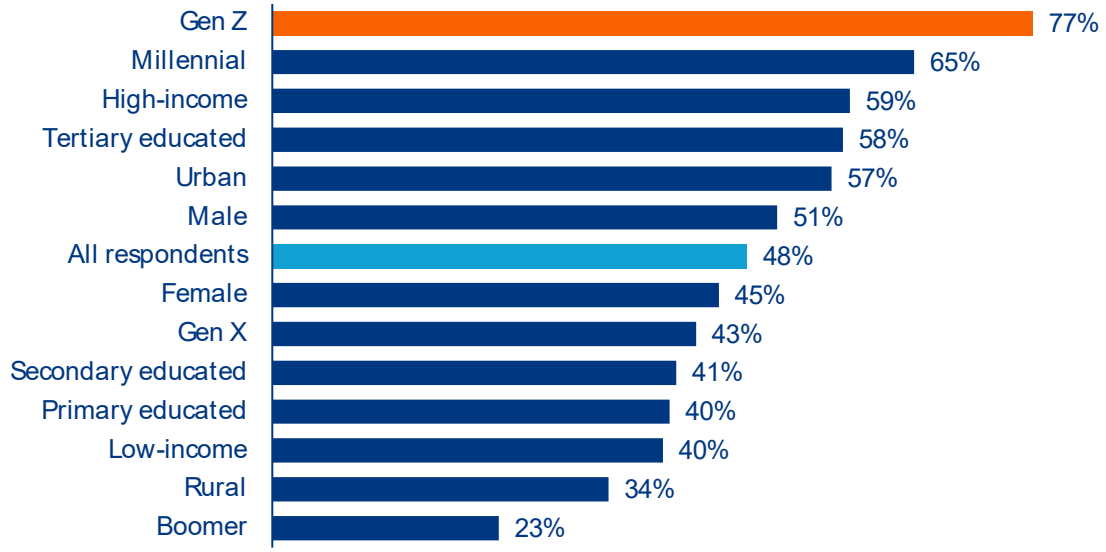
Age matters considerably more than country for how AI is used. Almost four in five Boomers (78%) use AI mainly privately, compared with only 8% mainly for work, although this partly reflects the fact that many in this age group are already entering or in retirement. Among Gen Z, the split is almost perfectly balanced: 35% use it mainly for work or study, 35% mainly privately and 30% for both. Millennials occupy the middle ground here, with 44% using AI mainly privately, 22% mainly for work or study and 34% for both. Notably, the gender gap in how AI is used is surprisingly small: men and women use AI across private and professional purposes in a similar way, even though weekly adoption remains somewhat higher among men than women, at 51% versus 45%.

Figure 1 : Broad but shallow AI adoption.
Frequency of AI use, share of respondents, in %



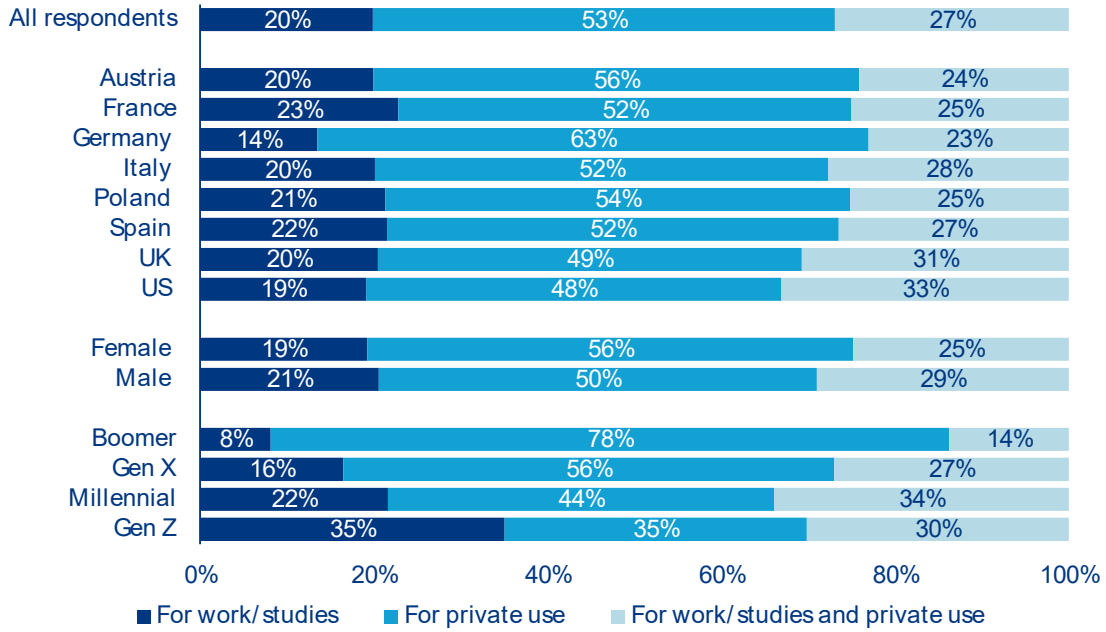
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Figure 2: Gen Z uses AI three times as often as Boomers.
Share using AI at least weekly, share of respondents, by group, in %



Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Figure 3: Private rather than for work and a generational divide.
Main context of AI use, share of respondents who are AI users, in %



Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

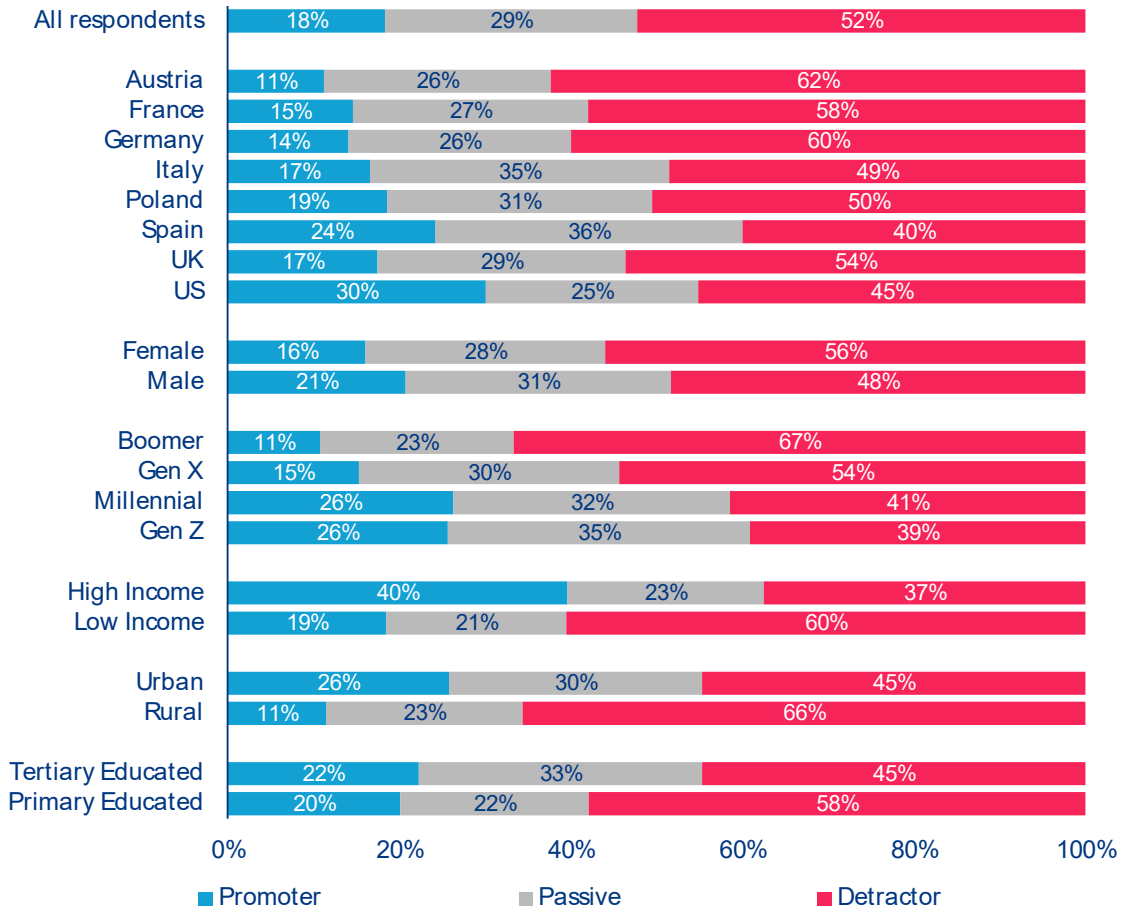


Attitudes: the wider the lens, the darker the view

AI is already widely used, but most people view the new technology with anxiety rather than enthusiasm (Figure 4). To capture respondents' overall attitude towards AI, we asked them to rate their general views about the technology on a scale from 0 (very negative) to 10 (very positive). Using the established net-promoter-score metric, we classify respondents into detractors (scores 0-6), passives (scores 7-8) and promoters (scores 9-10). Across all respondents in the eight countries surveyed, 52% classify as AI detractors, compared with just 18% promoters, while 29% fall in between as passives. In every country surveyed, the share of detractors far exceeds the share of promoters, underscoring people's high levels of uncertainty and anxiety around AI. Spain stands out as the country with the lowest share of AI detractors at 40% and the second-highest share of promotors at 24%. The most positive, or least negative, AI attitudes are found in the US with the highest promoter share at 30%. At the other end, the two countries with the most negative views about AI are Germany and Austria with only 14% and 11% promoters but 62% and 60% detractors, respectively.

The divide in AI attitudes is just as striking across demographic groups, pointing to a broader gap in who feels comfortable with the AI transition. Promoters are disproportionately young, urban and high-income. Almost 40% of high-income respondents are promoters, more than twice the share among low-income respondents (19%), while only 37% of the high-income group are detractors compared with 60% of the low-income group. Age shows an even sharper divide, with two-thirds of Boomers classified as detractors compared with 39% of Gen Z. Geography matters too: 66% of rural respondents are detractors, compared with 45% of urban respondents. Education, however, tells a more nuanced story. Tertiary-educated respondents are less likely to reject AI outright than those with only primary education, but they are not much more likely to embrace it: promoter shares are 22% and 20%, respectively. That may reflect the double-edged nature of AI for knowledge workers. They are better placed to use the technology, but many also work in occupations where tasks are especially exposed to the technology.

Figure 4: AI enthusiasm remains the minority view.
AI attitudes by country and demographic group, in % of respondents



Note: Respondents rated their overall attitude towards AI on a scale from 0 (very negative) to 10 (very positive). Detractors, passives and promoters follow the classification used throughout the report.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

The central finding is a striking gradient in AI attitudes, which become steadily more negative as the lens widens from the individual to the economy and the labor market. Having established who falls into the promoter, passive and detractor camps, we use the same classification to compare attitudes across different dimensions of AI (Figure 5). For each question, net sentiment is the share of promoters minus the share of detractors; passives therefore do not affect the balance. On this measure, sentiment towards AI in general stands at -34% across the sample, underscoring the dominant share of detractors. When we widen the lens to AI's effect on the economy, net sentiment falls to -43%. Widen it once more to AI's effect on jobs and it drops to a stark -67%, the most negative reading in the entire survey. The latter number means that the 75% of respondents with negative assessments outnumber the 8% of respondents with positive ones by 67pp. This gradient shows that people are relaxed about the tool in their own hands but fearful of it in the labor market. No single country or demographic group escapes this pattern.

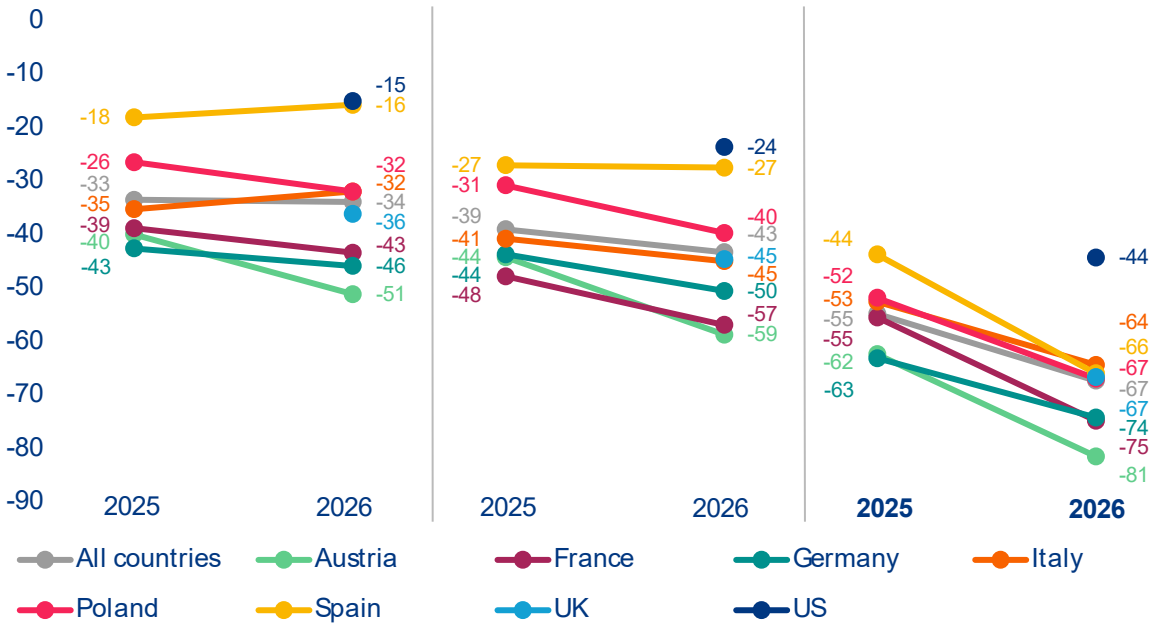
Across countries, the same downward gradient holds, but the intensity of AI skepticism varies sharply: the US is the most positive, Austria and France are the most negative, while Spain combines high overall enthusiasm with pronounced concern about jobs. Respondents from the US have consistently the mildest view on AI across general attitude, impact on the economy and jobs. In particular, the US reading of a net AI sentiment on jobs of -44%, stemming from 20% promoters and 64% detractors is the highest in the sample, although it is still deeply negative. On the other end of the spectrum, Austria is the most skeptical throughout, with net sentiment on AI's impact on jobs falling to -81%, followed closely by France at -75%. Spain provides perhaps

the most revealing contrast: it is the most enthusiastic European country towards AI in general, yet records the steepest deterioration when the lens shifts to jobs. High engagement with AI therefore does not remove concerns about labor-market disruption.

As AI adoption accelerates, public sentiment is moving in the opposite direction: attitudes towards the technology have deteriorated across the board over the past year. Comparing responses with 2025, sentiment towards AI in general has edged lower, views of its economic impact have become more negative and concerns about jobs have intensified most sharply. The net balance on employment plunged by 12 pp, from -55% to -67%, with Austria recording a particularly steep decline of around 19pp and Germany and France also seeing double-digit drops. The bottom line: the more widespread AI becomes, the more uneasy people feel about its consequences. And these concerns may have deepened further, as the survey predates the latest public debate around advanced AI and its safety risks.

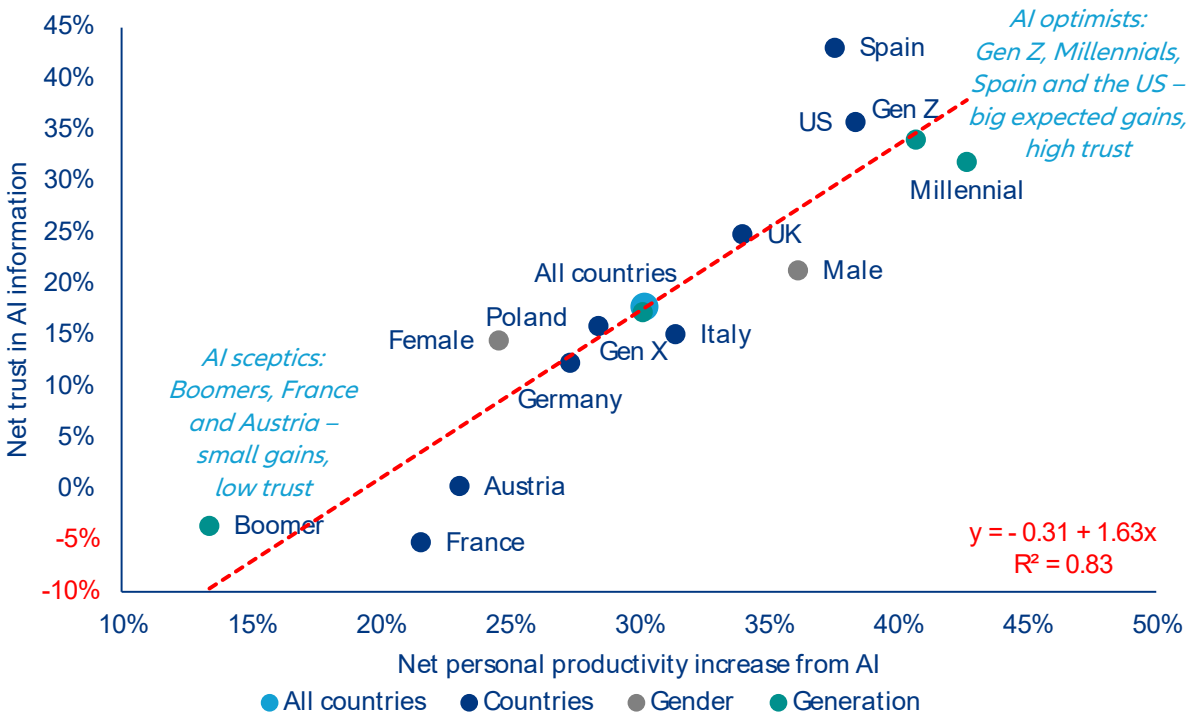
The one bright spot is the personal frame, where more people expect AI to help rather than to harm them, and productivity and trust move together (Figure 6). More respondents expect AI to raise their own productivity rather than to lower it, for a net of +30%. A slim majority trust the information AI provides, for a net of +18%. Trust and expected productivity move closely together across countries and demographic groups. France sits at the skeptical end, with net distrust of AI information at -5%, alongside Austria at close to zero and Boomers at -4%. At the other end are Spain (+43%), the US (+36%) and younger generations.

Figure 5: The wider the lens, the darker the view, and every frame has worsened.
Net AI sentiment for AI in general, its economic impact and its labor-market impact, 2025 versus 2026, in %



Note: The AI sentiment questions asked respondents to rate their attitudes on a scale from 0 (very negative) to 10 (very positive), following a net promoter score logic. Net sentiment is the share of promoters minus the share of detractors. The UK and US are observed in 2026 only.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Figure 6: Trust and expected productivity move together.
Net trust in AI information and net expected effect on personal productivity, share of respondents, in %



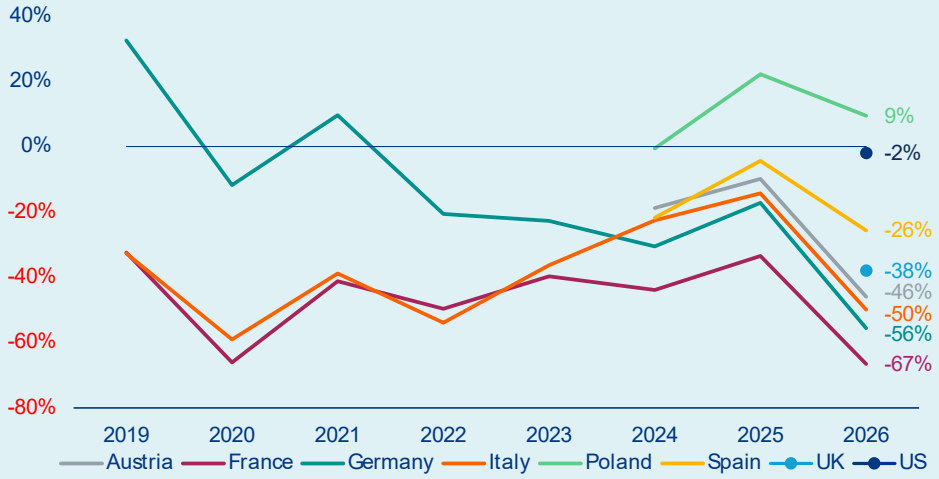
Note: Net values are the share positive minus the share negative.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Box 1: Is AI adding to the economic confidence crisis?

Every year, the Allianz Pulse tracks how households view the economy and their own prospects. In 2026, economic confidence fell back toward pandemic-era lows, raising a new question: Could growing fears about AI be adding to pessimism about both the near-term economic outlook and future generations' prospects for prosperity? As AI becomes part of everyday life and work, its potential to transform jobs, incomes and living standards adds a new dimension to how people assess their economic future.

Economic sentiment has deteriorated sharply across most countries. Since 2019, the Allianz Pulse has tracked assessments of current economic conditions and future prospects. Our economic sentiment indicator averages the net balances of positive minus negative responses to both questions. In 2026, it stands at -67% in France, -56% in Germany, -50% in Italy and -46% in Austria (Figure 7). Germany recorded the sharpest reversal, falling from -17% in 2025 to -56%, below even its reading during the Covid pandemic. Poland remains the only positive outlier at +9%, while the UK (-38%) reflects the subdued mood across Western Europe. The US, included for the first time, is close to neutral at -2%.

Figure 7: Economic confidence falls towards pandemic-era lows as AI adoption accelerates.
Net economic sentiment by country, 2019-2026, in %



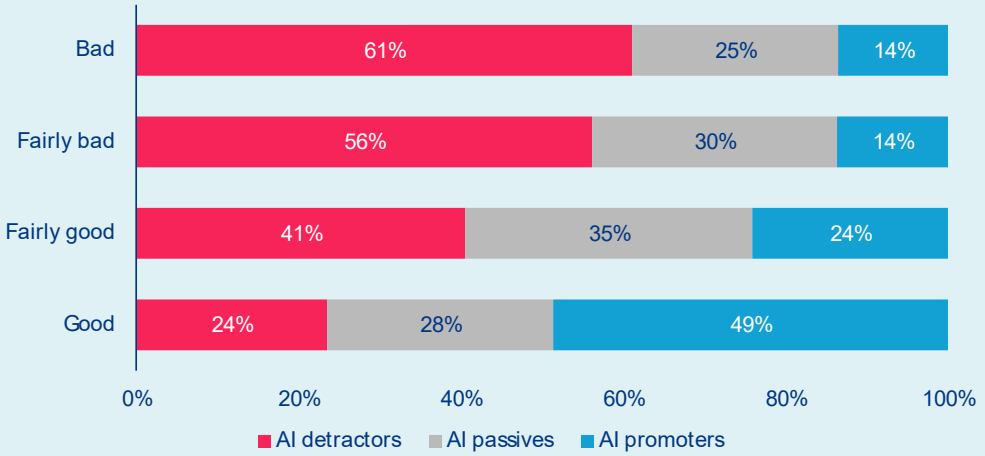
Note: Net sentiment is the average of the net balances for the current economic situation and future prospects, each defined as the share rating the economy good minus the share rating it bad. Austria, Poland and Spain enter the series in 2024; the UK and US in 2026.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Economic pessimism and AI skepticism are closely intertwined. Among respondents who assess the economy as "bad", 61% have negative views about AI and only 14% are positive about it. Among those who see the economy as "good", the picture is almost reversed: Just 24% are AI detractors, while 49% are promoters (Figure 8). The relationship is gradual: Moving from a "fairly bad" to a "fairly good" assessment reduces the detractor share from 56% to 41% and raises the promoter share from 14% to 24%. However, the direction of the relationship remains unclear. Economic pessimism may fuel AI skepticism, concerns about AI may weigh on confidence, or both may reflect broader anxieties about the future.

The relationship holds across countries, but its strength varies considerably. It is particularly pronounced in the US, where the share of AI detractors falls from 62% among respondents who rate the economy as bad to just 12% among those who rate it as good, while the promoter share rises from 19% to 68%. The UK and Germany show similarly steep

gradients, although the most economically optimistic groups are small and should be interpreted with caution. Spain stands out in the opposite direction: AI attitudes vary much less with economic confidence, and even respondents who assess the economy negatively remain comparatively receptive to the technology. The relationship between economic confidence and AI sentiment is therefore far from uniform across countries.

Figure 8: The better the view of the economy, the more AI promoters.
AI attitudes by assessment of the national economy, in %.



Note: Respondents are grouped according to their assessment of the current national economic situation as bad, fairly bad, fairly good or good. AI attitudes are classified as detractors, passives and promoters based on respondents' overall assessment of AI.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Beyond the immediate economic outlook, confidence in generational progress is also fading. Only 18% of respondents expect the next generation to be better off than today, while 50% expect it to be worse off, resulting in a net balance of -32%. Pessimism increases with age: The balance stands at -14% among Gen Z but falls to -43% among Boomers. The generation whose future is at stake is thus substantially more optimistic than older cohorts. The US stands out: Expectations for the next generation are close to neutral overall, and young Americans are the only group in the survey that expects future generations to be better off.

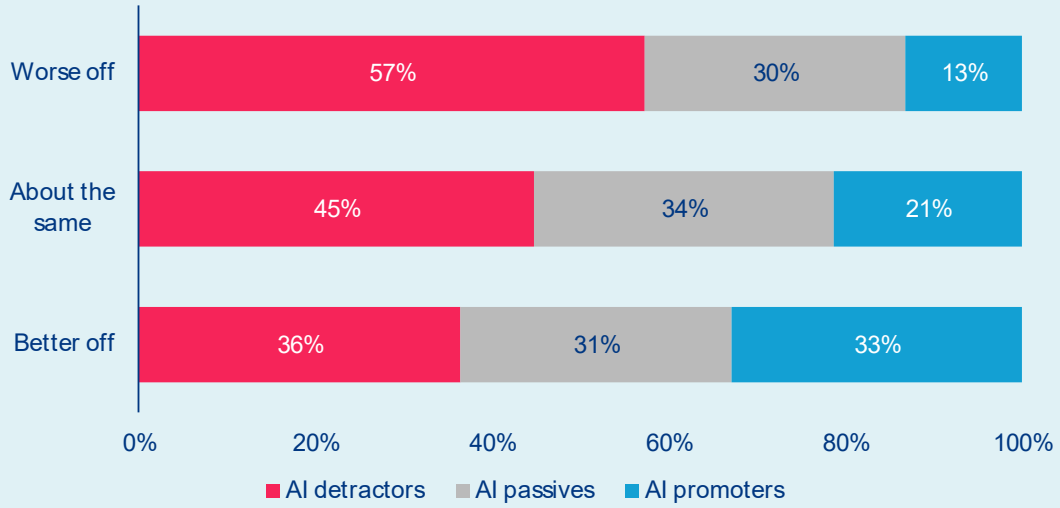
Doubts about generational progress go hand in hand with more negative views of AI. Only 18% of respondents expect the next generation to be better off than today, while half expect it to be worse off. Among respondents who expect the next generation to be worse off, 57% are AI detractors and only 13% promoters. Among those who expect an improvement, detractors and promoters are almost evenly matched, at 36% and 33%, respectively (Figure 9). This translates into a roughly 40pp difference in net AI sentiment, from -44% among generational pessimists to close to neutral (-4%) among optimists. The relationship holds across countries, although national differences remain significant. Among those expecting generational progress, net AI sentiment is positive in the US (+34%), the UK (+23%) and Spain (+3%), but remains negative in Germany, France and Austria.

The US offers a glimpse of how attitudes might evolve once the economic benefits of AI become more tangible
AI-related investment, including information-processing equipment, software, R&D and data centers, accounted for an estimated 39% of US real GDP growth in the first three quarters of 2025[1]. At the same time, rising equity valuations have boosted household wealth, with AI enthusiasm playing an important role. This wealth channel is particularly

[1] The Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis estimates that investment in information-processing equipment, software, R&D and data centers contributed 0.97pp to US real GDP growth in the first three quarters of 2025, equivalent to 39% of total growth. See: https://www.stlouisfed.org/on-the-economy/2026/jan/tracking-ai-contribution-gdp-growth

strong in the US, where households hold a much larger share of their financial assets in securities than their European counterparts. Americans are therefore experiencing AI not only as a potential source of labor-market disruption but also as an investment and wealth boom[2]. This may help explain why both economic sentiment and AI attitudes are less negative in the US, although the benefits remain unevenly distributed. The central challenge is to ensure that AI strengthens confidence in economic progress rather than becoming another source of insecurity. This will depend not only on delivering productivity gains but also on making their benefits visible, tangible and broadly shared.

Figure 9: AI optimism goes hand in hand with faith in generational progress.
AI attitudes by expectations for the next generation, in %



Note: Respondents are grouped according to whether they expect the next generation to be better off, about the same or worse off. AI attitudes are classified as detractors, passives and promoters based on respondents' overall assessment of AI.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

[2] Global financial assets increased by 8.6% in 2025, with valuation gains accounting for roughly 80% of the increase. See: Allianz Global Wealth Report 2026, https://www.allianz.com/en/economic_research/insights/publications/global-wealth-report-2026.html



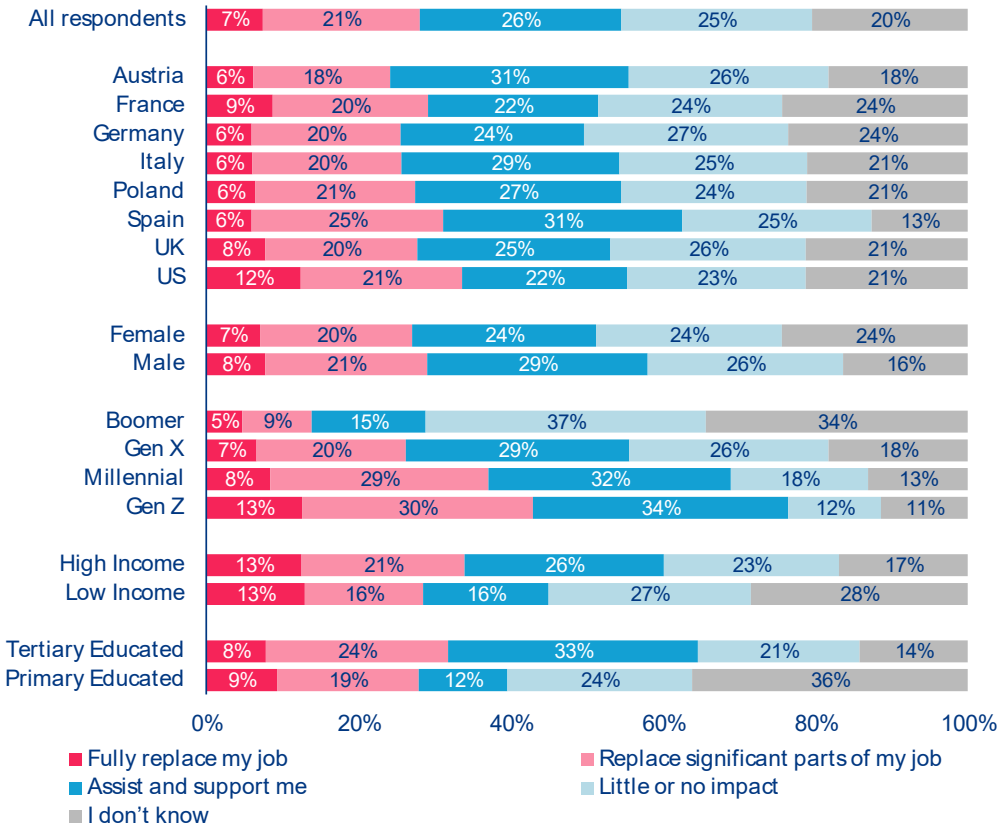
Jobs: rising concern, but task disruption rather than job destruction

People are deeply pessimistic about AI's impact on jobs in general, yet relatively few expect their own job to disappear. The bigger concern is how tasks will change and who will be able to adapt (Figure 10). Net sentiment towards AI's impact on jobs stands at -67%, the most negative reading on AI attitudes in the survey. However, only 7% of respondents expect AI to replace their own job entirely within the next five years. A further 21% expect significant parts of their work to be replaced, while 26% expect AI mainly to assist and augment what they do. Another 25% foresee little or no impact, while 20% do not know. The apparent paradox between very negative views of AI's overall impact on employment and relatively limited fears of personal job loss can therefore be reconciled: people expect AI to reshape tasks and job content even if they do not expect mass unemployment (see our forecast on the macroeconomic and labor market impact of AI in Box 2).

Across countries, the main difference is not whether people expect change, but whether they see AI primarily as a substitute, a complement or an unknown. The US records the highest expectation of outright displacement: 12% expect their job to disappear entirely, almost twice the European average, and another 21% expect significant parts to be replaced. Spain also anticipates substantial change, with 25% expecting significant task replacement, but this is matched by the highest share expecting AI to assist their work (31%, alongside Austria) and the lowest level of uncertainty in the sample at just 13%. Austria similarly leans towards augmentation, with 31% expecting AI to assist and support them. France and Germany, by contrast, stand out less for replacement fears than for uncertainty: around one in four respondents do not know how AI will affect their job. These differences suggest that labor-market anxiety has different forms across countries: substitution fears are more pronounced in the US, expectations of task reconfiguration are strongest in Spain, while parts of Europe remain unsure about what the transition will mean in practice.

Expectations of both augmentation and automation due to AI are highest among younger and highly-educated respondents, the same groups that are also more exposed to the technology in their daily lives and work. Some 43% of Gen Z expect AI to replace their job either entirely or in significant part, compared with just 14% of Boomers. At the same time, 34% of Gen Z expect AI mainly to assist them at work, more than twice the share among Boomers (15%), while only 11% say they do not know what AI will mean for their job, compared with 34% of Boomers. A similar pattern emerges by education. Almost one-third of tertiary-educated respondents expect full or significant replacement (32%), compared with 28% among those with primary education, but they are also almost three times as likely to expect augmentation (33% versus 12%) and far less likely to be uncertain (14% versus 36%). Income differences point in the same direction: high-income respondents are somewhat more likely than low-income respondents to expect full or significant replacement (34% versus 29%), but also more likely to expect AI to assist them (26% versus 17%), while uncertainty is much higher among low-income respondents (29% versus 17%). The divide is therefore not simply between groups that expect disruption and those that do not: the groups most exposed to AI tend to expect more change in both directions, while less exposed groups are much more uncertain about what the technology will mean for them.

Figure 10 : More expect disruption than outright replacement, but a fifth simply do not know.
Expected effect of AI on own job in five years, share of respondents, in %



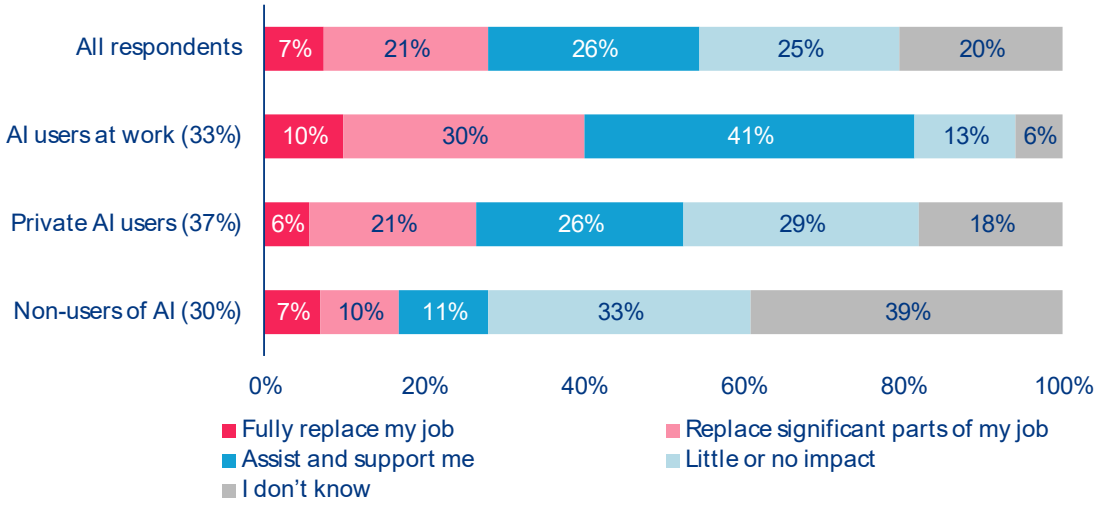
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

To assess whether direct exposure to AI changes how people expect it to affect their jobs, we split respondents into three mutually exclusive groups according to how they currently use the technology. Around one-third already use AI at work (33%), comprising both those who use it mainly at work and equally at work and at home, while 37% use it only privately and 30% do not use AI at all. We then compare expectations for AI's impact on their own job across these three groups, using the full sample as a benchmark. This allows us to distinguish whether greater exposure is associated primarily with fears of replacement, expectations of augmentation or simply a clearer view of how work is likely to change.

The more people use AI at work, the more job transformation they expect, but exposure raises expectations of augmentation even more strongly than fears of replacement (Figure 11). Among AI users at work, 40% expect AI to replace their job entirely or take over significant parts of it, compared with just 17% of non-users. However, the gap is even larger on the positive side: 41% of workplace users expect AI mainly to assist and support them, almost four times the 11% share among non-users. This asymmetry fits with our earlier finding that people who already use AI tend to view the technology more positively. Exposure appears to make both the disruptive and complementary potential of AI more tangible, but it is especially the expected upside that is missing among non-users.

The other striking gradient is uncertainty, which falls sharply as exposure to AI increases. Only 11% expect augmentation, while 33% foresee little or no impact and another 39% simply do not know what AI will mean for their job. Together, almost three-quarters of non-users therefore either expect no meaningful effect or cannot yet assess one, compared with just 19% of workplace users. Private-only users again occupy the middle ground: 27% expect full or significant replacement, 26% augmentation, 30% little or no impact and 18% remain uncertain. The gradient suggests that direct experience shifts perceptions away from indifference and uncertainty towards a much more concrete view of AI as both a source of task substitution and a tool for productive support. AI users have thus a much clearer view of how the technology could change their work, seeing both greater disruption and substantially greater potential for augmentation.

Figure 11: AI users at work see AI mainly as an assistant but also fear most for their job.
Expected effect of AI on own job in five years by type of AI users, share of respondents, in %



Note: Groups based on "In which context do you mainly use AI tools?": AI users at work = mainly for work/studies or equally for work/studies and private purposes; private AI users = mainly for private purposes; non-users = do not use AI yet (incl. those planning to) or do not plan to use it. The shares of the groups are given in parentheses.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Box 2: AI and the labor market: Disruption first, productivity gains later

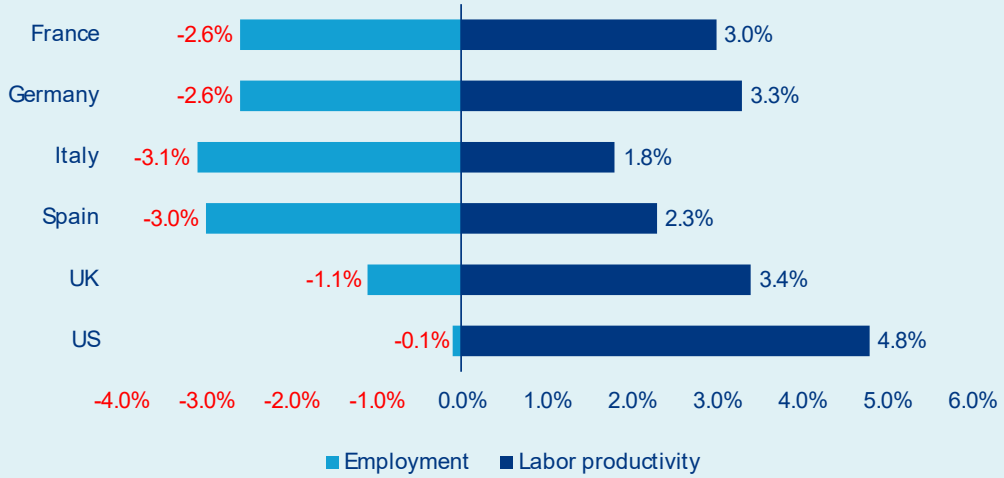
AI is likely to reshape far more jobs than it destroys, but the scale of labor-market adjustment will still be substantial. Our estimates suggest that AI could affect 23% of jobs across the major advanced economies over the next one to three years[3]. The estimate is built bottom-up from more than 800 occupations, which we classify according to four possible AI impacts: no exposure, automation, augmentation or reorganization. We aggregate these occupation-level effects into sectoral AI-exposure scores and then to the country level, taking into account sectoral employment shares as well as structural factors such as AI adoption and preparedness, labor-market regulation and unit labor costs. Job reorganization is the largest channel, accounting for 10% of jobs, as workers remain in their roles but AI takes over or changes some of their tasks. A further 8% of jobs face a higher risk of automation, while 5% could benefit from augmentation. Exposure across countries differs markedly, largely because of differences in their sectoral composition as well as structural factors, such as labor market regulations and the institutional context. In the US, where finance, ICT and other knowledge-intensive services account for a larger share of employment, 29% of jobs could be affected, compared with 15% across the major European economies. Within Europe, the share ranges from 18% in the UK and 16% in Germany to 14% in France, 12% in Spain and just 9% in Italy. The US therefore faces greater near-term disruption, but is also better-positioned to capture the productivity and employment gains from AI.

The first effects are likely to appear in hiring and job composition rather than in a sudden rise in aggregate unemployment. Early evidence already points in this direction: more AI-intensive sectors in the Eurozone have seen weaker employment growth since late 2022, while younger and less-experienced white-collar workers in routine cognitive occupations appear particularly exposed. AI may therefore initially show up through fewer entry-level positions, slower hiring and weaker wage growth in exposed occupations rather than large-scale layoffs. The main medium-term risk is a transition gap: firms can reorganize and automate tasks faster than workers can move into newly created roles. Around 25mn jobs across the US and the major European economies are estimated to be subject to automation risk, while new AI-related employment will only partly offset displacement in the near and medium term.

Over the longer term, we expect both substantial productivity gains and a moderately negative impact on employment, but the gains are likely to be larger in the US than in Europe (Figure 12). Our ten-year estimates assume that the AI transition follows a so-called J-curve, with investments and costs upfront, while the gains will only be realized later[4]. AI-related investment already adds around 0.4pp to US GDP growth in 2026, but the immediate productivity gains are limited as they get absorbed by reorganization costs and labor-market adjustment. By 2030, US GDP is projected to grow +0.6% faster annually, while employment will be 1.5% lower relative to a world without AI. Thereafter, the productivity dividend becomes more visible: by 2036, cumulative labor productivity is around +4.8% above the no-AI baseline in the US, while the employment effect largely unwinds to -0.1%, equivalent to roughly -170,000 jobs. In Europe, productivity gains are more muted and employment effects more persistent: employment remains below the no-AI baseline across the major economies, reaching around -2.9% in Spain (-650,000 jobs) and -3.1% in Italy (-740,000 jobs), while Italy records the smallest productivity gain at around +1.8%. Germany and France also remain below baseline on employment, although by less than Spain and Italy. However, these employment losses will unfold against a rapidly shrinking workforce in the ageing European societies: by 2036, labor supply is set to decline by 5.6mn workers in Germany, 4.2mn in Italy and 2.3mn in Spain. Europe therefore faces a double labor-market challenge from demographic change and AI. The silver lining is that AI may partly compensate for a shrinking workforce in aggregate, but not one-for-one, because AI-related displacement will not necessarily occur in the same occupations, sectors and regions where labor shortages emerge. Overall, the US combines the highest near-term AI exposure with the smallest long-run employment loss, reflecting faster adoption, stronger investment and more effective reallocation. Europe, by contrast, faces a more persistent employment drag and smaller productivity gains, but part of the AI-related displacement could help cushion the effects of ageing.

[3] See: Allianz Research (2026), "Happy Labor Day? How geopolitics, immigration and AI will reshape work," 30 April 2026,
[4] See: Allianz Research (2026), "Half-Time Outlook 2026-27: AI holds the score, growth slows to +2.5%", 8 July 2026,

Figure 12: More productivity, but also labor-market adjustment.
Cumulative 10-year impact of AI on employment and productivity relative to no-AI baseline, in %



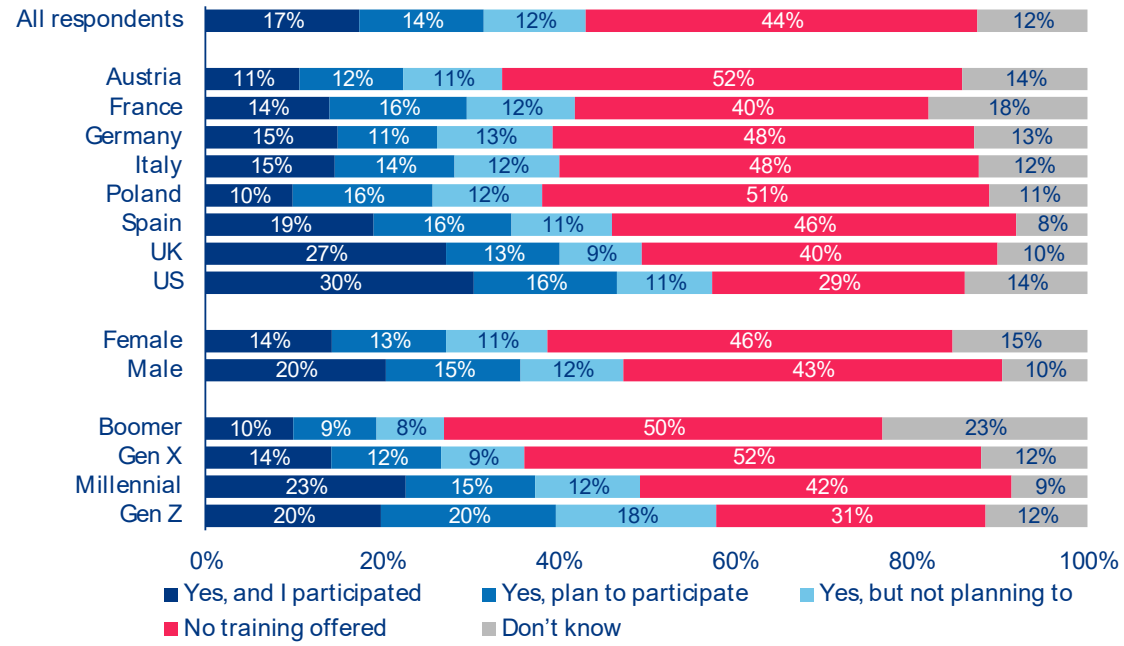
Sources: LSEG Datastream, Bloomberg, Allianz Research.

Preparedness: so far training reaches mainly those already ahead

The preparedness gap is starkest in training: adaptation is reaching those already ahead faster than those most in need of it. Among employed respondents, only 17% have received AI training at work, while 44% say their employer offers none (Figure 13). Participation reaches 30% among employed Americans but just 10% among Poles, and is markedly higher for men than women, at 21% against 14%. The education gradient is steeper still, with tertiary-educated employees roughly three times as likely to have received training as the secondary-educated. The generational pattern is more nuanced: Millennials, rather than Gen Z, record the highest training participation, promoter share and productivity expectations, while Gen Z is more likely to be offered training but decline it. The result is a preparedness gap between anticipated disruption and actual investment in adaptation. Left unchecked, AI diffusion risks reinforcing existing advantages rather than broadening opportunity.

Two demographic patterns sharpen that preparedness challenge. The first is that the gender divide is often one of uncertainty rather than outright opinion. Across multiple questions, women are substantially more likely than men to answer "don't know", with the gap reaching 25% versus 14% on AI's effect on inequality and 28% versus 20% on whether their own job will change. Women are therefore not consistently more hostile to AI; they are less certain about its implications. The second is a recurring U-shape by financial strain. Both the financially comfortable and the most strained tend to be more engaged and more polarized than those in the middle, whether in their overall attitudes, expected job disruption or willingness to retrain. Even among respondents who find it very easy to make ends meet, a majority still see AI as negative for jobs. Labor-market anxiety is therefore not confined to the economically vulnerable.

Figure 13 : The training gap, participation in employer AI training among the employed. Share of respondents, in %



Note: Employed respondents only, rescaled to exclude those not in work.
Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

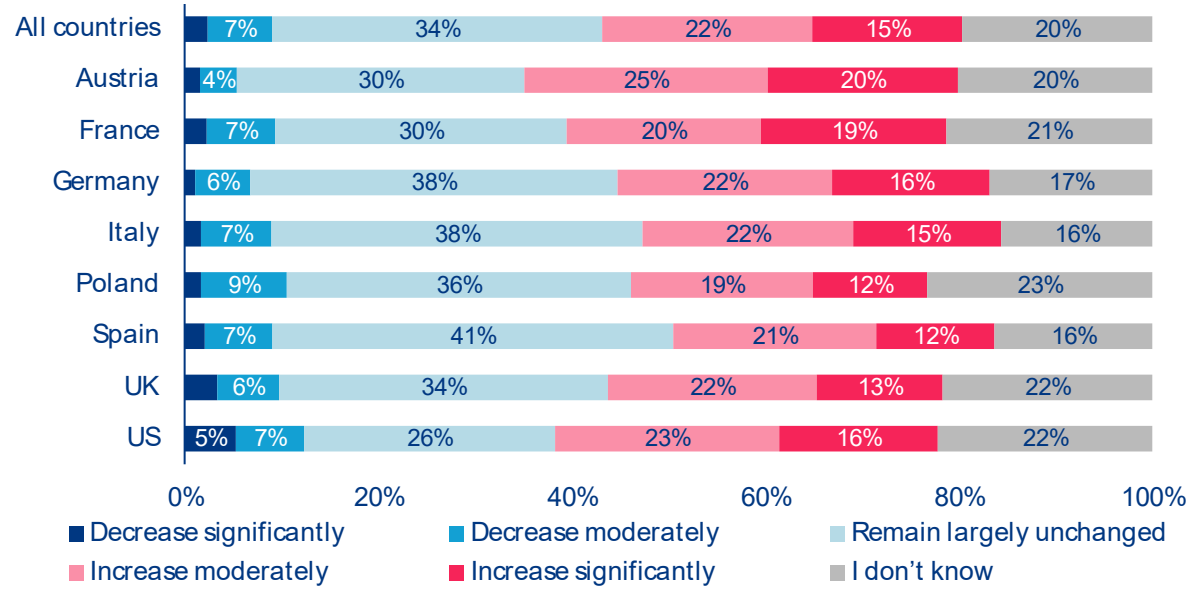


Inequality, misinformation and privacy concerns: people's worries culminate in a call for stricter regulation

Beyond their own jobs, people expect AI to widen the gap between winners and losers (Figure 14). Across the sample, 37% expect AI to increase inequality in their country, against just 9% who expect it to narrow, for a net of +28%. This concern is shared across all countries, from Austria (+40%) to Poland (+20%). The fear is not simply that AI will replace jobs, but that its benefits will accrue to some while others bear the costs. Together with widespread concerns about labor-market disruption, these findings point to a broader anxiety about who will benefit from the AI revolution. The challenge is therefore not only to unlock AI's productivity potential but also to ensure that its gains are widely shared.

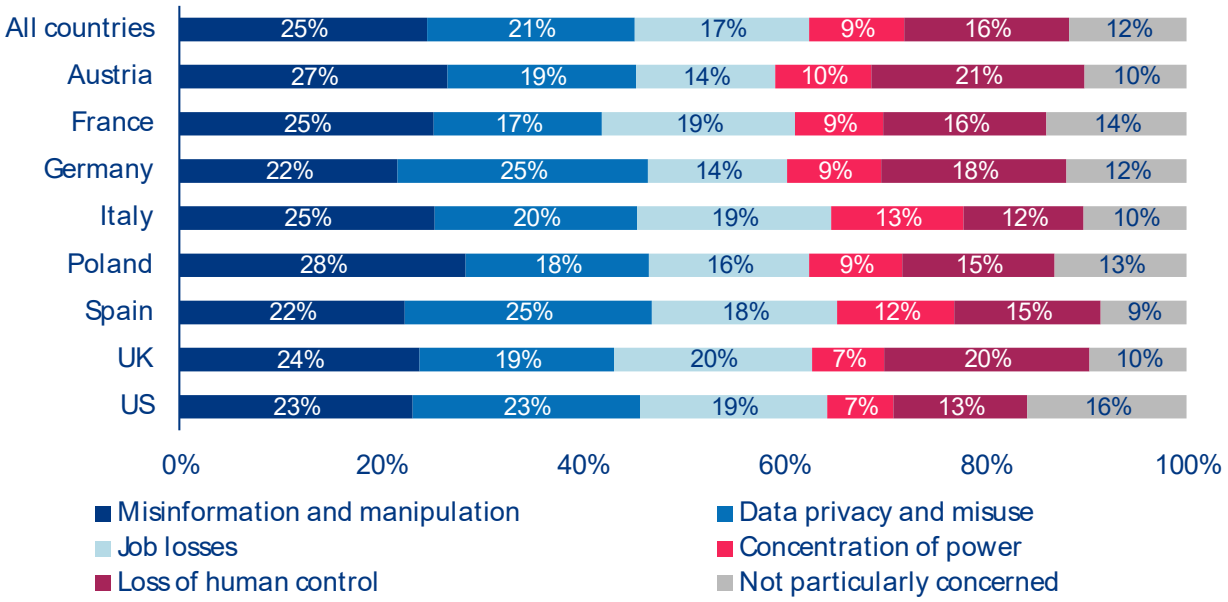
For most people, AI's biggest risks are not hypothetical future scenarios but immediate threats to information, privacy and jobs. Misinformation and information manipulation top the list of concerns, cited by 25% of respondents, followed by data privacy and misuse of personal information (21%) and job losses (17%) (Figure 15). The pattern is remarkably consistent across countries, from Austria to the US. The loss of human control over advanced AI systems, a prominent concern in the AI-safety debate, ranks fourth at 16%, while the concentration of power among large technology companies is cited by 9%, with particularly limited concern in the US, home to the leading AI developers. Only 12% of respondents say they have no concerns about AI at all. The message is clear: People are worried less about what AI might become than about the harm it can already cause.

Figure 14 : A clear expectation that AI will widen inequality.
Expected effect of AI on inequality, share of respondents, in %,



Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

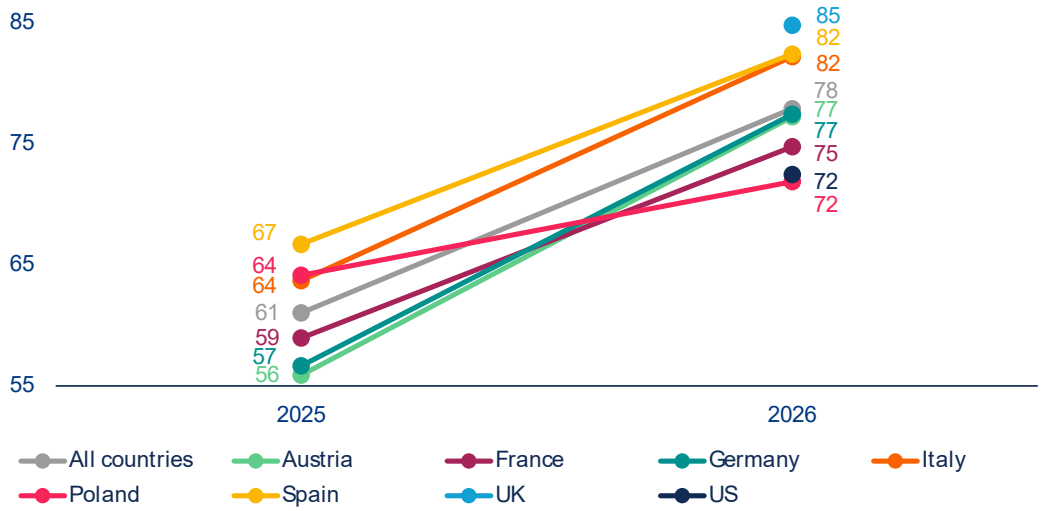
Figure 15 : Misinformation and privacy top the worry list, not loss of control.
Main concern about AI, by country, share of respondents, in %



Source: Allianz Pulse 2026, Allianz Research.

Faced with these risks, the public is sending policymakers an increasingly clear message: AI needs stronger guardrails. Across the sample, the net regulation score – the share favoring strict or some regulation minus those opposing regulation – has risen to 78%, up from 61% in 2025 (Figure 16). Support is strongest in the UK (85%) and Spain (82%) but exceeds 70% in every surveyed country, while only around 5% favor no regulation. Crucially, demand for safeguards is not confined to AI skeptics: Even respondents who expect AI to improve their own productivity want stronger oversight. People appear willing to embrace AI's benefits, but not to accept its risks unchecked. The survey also predates the recent wave of high-profile AI-related cybersecurity incidents, which could further heighten public attention to safety and accountability[5].

Figure 16 : An overwhelming and growing call for stricter AI regulation.
Net regulation score by country, 2025 versus 2026, in %



Note: Net regulation is the share wanting strict or some regulation minus the share wanting none. The UK and US are observed in 2026 only.

[5] See: Financial Times (2026), "Hugging Face attack is a wake-up call about the risks of AI", 3 September 2026.

Governments have taken significantly different approaches on AI regulation, with the US and the EU representing contrasting models (Table 1). The US has no comprehensive federal AI law, relying on a patchwork of state-level legislation and existing sectoral rules, alongside federal efforts to limit divergent state requirements. California has emerged as a leading state regulator, introducing requirements addressing transparency, safety and specific uses of AI. The UK also relies largely on existing sectoral and cross-cutting legislation, with additional measures under consideration where gaps emerge. The EU, by contrast, has established a comprehensive, risk-based framework through its AI Act. In force since 2024, its obligations are being phased in through 2028, with member states responsible for much of the national enforcement framework. Italy has also introduced supplementary national legislation, including criminal provisions[6]. Outside the EU, public demand for regulation thus runs well ahead of the rules in place.

The policy challenge is not simply to regulate more, but to regulate what matters without stifling innovation. Too little regulation can leave firms with weak incentives to account for safety risks and other harms, while allowing concentration in areas such as hardware and data to entrench incumbents. Too much or poorly designed regulation can raise the cost of experimentation, slow AI adoption and investment and weigh disproportionately on smaller firms, which are less able to absorb compliance costs[7]. The objective for policymakers should therefore be to address harmful externalities and preserve trust and competition while keeping barriers to experimentation and diffusion as low as possible. As public demand for regulation rises, getting this balance right will become increasingly important.

Table 1 : Key AI regulation across the EU, UK and US

Country	Key regulation	Type and scope	Details	Status
European Union	EU AI Act (Reg. 2024/1689), amended by the Digital AI Omnibus (Reg. 2026/1744) + GDPR for personal data. *National layer: Italy adds stricter national rules (Law 132/2025) on top.*	Binding, horizontal, risk-based framework	EU-wide rules that scale with risk: bans on prohibited practices, strict requirements for high-risk AI, transparency duties for generative AI and deepfakes, and obligations for general-purpose AI (GPAI) model providers.	In force, phased: bans and GPAI rules apply; transparency since Aug 2026; high-risk rules from Dec 2027 (stand-alone) / Aug 2028 (in products).
United Kingdom	No dedicated AI law. UK GDPR + Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 (automated decision-making rules)	Sectoral/regulator-led	AI is covered by existing law: data protection, consumer, equality, competition, online safety and sector rules, enforced by regulators as ICO, FCA, Ofcom	No AI bill planned. Bill announced May 2026 to allow AI test sandboxes (temporary rule relaxation). Automated decision-making rules in force since Feb 2026.
United States	No federal AI law. Existing federal law (FTC Act, sector rules) + state AI laws. Dec 2025 executive order (EO 14365) pushes to challenge state laws	Fragmented federal/state	FTC and sector regulators apply existing law. States are adding their own AI rules, while the federal government tries to limit them through the DOJ AI Litigation Task Force and by asking Congress for a single national standard.	Fragmented and evolving. No federal preemption yet. 29 Sep 2026: six frontier AI firms signed a voluntary, non-binding safety accord. Several state frontier-AI and automated decision-making laws take effect 1 Jan 2027.

Sources: national governments as of 7 October 2026, Allianz Research.

[6] Italy's Law 132/2025 made it the first EU member state to enact a standalone national AI law, introducing new criminal offences for deepfakes and AI misuse. In June 2026, two implementing decrees further operationalized the framework, covering enforcement, sanctions, and liability.
[7] See: Bruegel, June 2026, "The right balance: how to fix European Union artificial intelligence regulation" ; Brookings, September 2024, "Balancing market innovation incentives and regulation in AI: Challenges and opportunities"

Policy priorities: adopting AI better, not just faster

For Europe, the central challenge is not simply to accelerate AI adoption, but to turn widespread experimentation into productive, inclusive and trusted use Curiosity is not the main constraint: Europeans have embraced AI almost as widely as Americans, but the technology has made fewer inroads into the workplace, and workers are less prepared to use it effectively. The priority is therefore to remove the barriers that prevent AI from translating into productivity gains and broader economic benefits. This requires action on five fronts:

1. Move AI from private experimentation into productive workplace use. General-purpose technologies like AI generate productivity gains only after firms make large complementary investments. These investments show up as costs today, dragging down earnings and productivity in the short run, the so-called productivity J-curve. Because the costs are immediate while the benefits are delayed, private investment may fall short, in particular for SMEs, which face disproportionately high costs for the same implementation effort[8]. Europe should reduce these costs that are holding back implementation, especially for SMEs, through accelerated depreciation or temporary tax credits for identifiable complementary investments such as software integration, data infrastructure, cybersecurity and process redesign. Public support should be tied to actual deployment in business processes and, where possible, measurable productivity or efficiency gains rather than generic AI subscriptions.

2. Close the training gap by starting with employers. This is primarily a provision problem: many workers receive no offer of AI training, while most of those offered it take it up or plan to do so. Employer-led training should therefore be supported through training tax credits, public co-financing and individual learning accounts, with a focus on occupation-specific skills and groups currently least served including women, mid-career workers, the secondary-educated and employees in smaller firms. Europe already has useful instruments: Germany's "Qualifizierungschancengesetz" subsidizes training costs and, in some cases, wage costs for employees affected by technological change, while the EU encourages member states to develop individual learning accounts that give workers portable training entitlements. Where firms receive public support for major AI investments, this could be linked to a workforce-training plan.

3. Shift labor-market policy from protecting jobs to supporting transitions. Because AI is likely to change tasks and occupations more extensively than it eliminates jobs outright, governments need to identify adjustment pressures before they translate into unemployment. Combining occupation-level AI-exposure indicators with vacancy, wage and skill-demand data can help identify vulnerable workers and emerging employment opportunities. Workers in exposed occupations should have access to retraining while still employed, stronger job-matching services, mobility grants and temporary wage insurance where moving into a new role initially means lower pay. Such measures must go beyond traditional active labor-market programs, whose short-term effects are often limited and vary considerably across program types and participants. Better targeting is crucial:

[8] For productivity discussion, see: Brynjolfsson, Rock & Syverson 2021. „The Productivity J-Curve: How Intangibles Complement General Purpose Technologies," American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics. For SMEs discussion, see: OECD 2025, "AI adoption by small and medium-sized enterprises",

programs that invest in human capital accumulation, such as classroom-based vocational training and on-the-job traineeships, show large gains, in particular for the long-term unemployed, whose skills have eroded during extended periods out of work, and for women[9]. Recent evidence confirms that well-designed interventions do indeed deliver: cost-benefit analyses show that such training schemes can be highly cost effective, and programs combining part-time work placements with training and short-term community work placements for the unemployed produce lasting earnings gains for participants[10]. The key lesson is therefore to replace broad, expensive programs with measures that are tightly linked to real-time labor-market signals.

4. Make sure the productivity dividend is broadly shared. AI is likely to raise productivity but could also shift national income from labor to capital, and if automation outruns capital accumulation, wages could fall even while output rises[11]. Policy should therefore address both labor income and household wealth. On the income side, broader access to skills can help translate productivity gains into better employment prospects and wages. . On the asset side, funded pensions, employee share plans and wider household capital-market participation can help more people benefit directly from AI-driven returns, particularly in Europe, where equity ownership is heavily concentrated among wealthier households[12]. At the same time, the tax system should avoid unnecessarily favoring capital over labor and adapt if a larger share of income shifts toward capital and economic rents. Europe is particularly exposed here, as its tax systems rely more heavily on labor income taxes and social contributions than the US, potentially putting greater pressure on public finances if the labor share of income declines[13].

5. Strengthen trust by targeting the risks people actually identify. Misinformation, data misuse and labor-market disruption point to different policy needs, so regulation should be targeted rather than generic: provenance and disclosure standards for synthetic content, clear rules and effective enforcement for data use, and human oversight and appeal rights for high-impact AI decisions. Rules should be credible and proportionate: safeguards that build trust can support adoption, while complex or inconsistent requirements can slow diffusion, especially for smaller firms. EU-wide templates, sector-specific guidance and regulatory sandboxes can help make implementation more predictable without weakening protections.

[9] See: Card D., Kluve J., Weber A., 2018. "What works? A Meta Analysis of Recent Active Labor Market Program Evaluations", Journal of the European Economic Association.
[10] See evidence on Slovenia active labor market policies: OECD, 2026. "The wide-ranging effects of active labour market policies in Slovenia: Lessons learnt and implications for other countries" ; and evidence on the effectiveness of Ireland's Community Employment and Tús schemes: OECD, 2024: "Impact Evaluation of Ireland's Active Labour Market Policies",
[11] Korinek & Suh, 2024. Scenarios for the transition to AGI, NBER WP 32255.
[12] See: ECB, 15 September 2026. "Why Europeans save differently, and how to put those savings to work"
[13] The Economist, 29 September 2026. "How the AI boom could worsen the rich world's fiscal crunch"

Appendix:
Survey summary statistics

The survey queried more than 8,000 respondents across eight countries: Austria, France, Germany, Italy, Poland, Spain, the United Kingdom and the United States. It was conducted as a web-based survey between 22 April and 25 May 2026. Overall responsibility lies with Allianz Research, Allianz Investment Management SE. Sample planning and fieldwork were carried out by Qualtrics.

Respondents were selected using representative quota sampling. Qualtrics was given quotas specifying how many people to survey in each country and which selection criteria to apply, with quotas set in line with official statistics for gender and age groups. A comparison with official statistics confirms that the resulting sample broadly corresponds to the population aged 18 and over in each of the eight countries.

Appendix Table 1: Sample statistics

	Total	Austria	France	Germany	Italy	Poland	Spain	UK	USA
Number of respondents	8048	1006	1006	1006	1006	1006	1006	1006	1006
Gender, in % of respondents									
Female	50.6%	50.0%	51.4%	49.9%	50.7%	50.9%	50.4%	50.9%	51.0%
Male	49.2%	50.0%	48.2%	49.9%	49.1%	49.0%	49.4%	48.9%	48.9%
Age groups, in % of respondents									
Gen Z	15.5%	15.4%	16.1%	13.6%	13.1%	15.2%	14.3%	16.9%	19.6%
Millennial	25.9%	26.8%	24.8%	25.8%	21.9%	27.0%	24.5%	28.3%	27.8%
Gen X	31.5%	34.1%	30.2%	26.2%	35.8%	33.6%	41.1%	25.0%	25.6%
Boomer	27.2%	23.7%	28.9%	34.3%	29.3%	24.3%	20.2%	29.8%	27.0%
Education, in % of respondents									
Primary (less than high school)	4.8%	2.2%	3.7%	2.6%	14.1%	4.0%	2.8%	2.0%	7.2%
Secondary (high school)	52.5%	75.2%	47.9%	69.2%	52.5%	55.2%	36.0%	43.6%	40.1%
Tertiary (university or comparable)	42.7%	22.6%	48.4%	28.2%	33.4%	40.9%	61.2%	54.4%	52.8%

Generation definition	Birth years
Gen Alpha*	2013 - 2031
Gen Z	1997 - 2012
Millennial	1981 - 1996
Gen X	1965 - 1980
Boomer	1946 - 1964
Silent**	1928 - 1945

* Not part of the survey sample.
** Not mentioned in the analysis as it was a very small portion of respondents.


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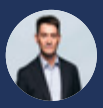
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